Use ChatGPT to Get What You Know About Mom's Finances Onto One Page

Four prompts to sort what you know, find what hasn't turned up yet, write down what care is costing, and line up your questions by who can answer them.

Where you are

Mom needs care now and the bills have started arriving. The financial information you suddenly need has never been organized, and nobody is sure exactly what she owns or receives each month.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share. Leave out account numbers, Social Security numbers, and passwords. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not decide what counts for Medicaid, whether anyone may qualify, or what to do with money or property. Rules vary by state; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

What you'll have at the end

You have one page showing what you know about her income, accounts, property, insurance, and care costs, what you still need to find, and the questions to bring to a professional.

A one-page list: What we know, What we still need to find, What care is costing, and Questions to ask, with who to ask.

Before you start

- Whatever statements, bills, and letters you've been able to find. A rough pile is fine.
- The most recent bill or rate sheet from the facility or care provider, if there is one.
- Your own notes on what you think Mom owns and receives. You don't need everything.

PROMPT 1

Start with what you actually know

WHY THIS MATTERS

When bills are arriving, it's easy to guess at the whole picture. Start with what's in front of you: the statements you've found and the things you know for sure.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your rough notes on income, accounts, property, and insurance. Leave out account numbers.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother needs long-term care now and I'm trying to get her finances organized. Here is what I know so far, in no particular order:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES, WITHOUT ACCOUNT NUMBERS]
>
> Using only what I've written, sort it under these headings: MONTHLY INCOME, BANK ACCOUNTS, INVESTMENTS AND RETIREMENT ACCOUNTS, INSURANCE AND ANNUITIES, REAL ESTATE AND OTHER PROPERTY, DEBTS. Beside each item, note whether I gave an amount, whether I said whose name it is in, and whether I said where the paperwork is. Where I said nothing under a heading, write "nothing listed yet". Do not add anything I didn't mention, do not total anything, and do not comment on what any of it means for Medicaid.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A sorted list in your own words, with the blanks showing.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the list. You'll build on it in the next prompt.

PROMPT 2

Find what hasn't turned up yet

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families often come across an account, a policy, or a pension later than they would like. The most useful thing the AI can do here is ask about the places you haven't looked.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The sorted list from the first prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the list of my mother's finances as I know them today:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULT OF PROMPT 1]
>
> Based only on this list, ask me about things families commonly have that I haven't mentioned: Social Security, pensions, retirement accounts, CDs, life insurance, annuities, long-term care insurance, real estate, vehicles, jointly owned accounts, and debts. Then list the documents I could look for to fill each blank, such as recent statements, tax returns, insurance policies, and property records. Phrase everything as a question or as something to look for. Don't assume anything exists.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A short list of places to look and people to ask.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick the items you can check this week: the mail, last year's tax return, a call to a brother or sister.

PROMPT 3

Write down what care is costing

WHY THIS MATTERS

The bills are the other half of the picture. Putting the monthly charges beside Mom's other regular expenses, in one list, gives you something specific to bring to a professional.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The latest bill or rate sheet from the facility or care provider, and a rough list of her other regular monthly expenses.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I know about what my mother's care and her other regular expenses cost each month:
>
> [PASTE WHAT THE BILLS SAY]
>
> Make a simple list with three columns: the expense, the monthly amount as I wrote it, and where the number came from (a bill, a rate sheet, or my own estimate). Mark anything I estimated. Then list questions I could ask the facility or provider about charges I don't understand or that may be billed separately. Do not estimate missing amounts, do not project anything forward, and do not tell me how long her money will last.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A list where every number has a source and the estimates are marked.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask the billing office the questions on the list.

PROMPT 4

Sort your questions by who can answer them

WHY THIS MATTERS

Some gaps you can close by opening the mail or calling the bank. Others need a professional. Knowing which is which is the point of this guide.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've organized about my mother's finances and care costs:
>
> [PASTE EVERYTHING FROM PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Give me one page with four headings: WHAT WE KNOW, WHAT WE STILL NEED TO FIND, WHAT CARE IS COSTING, and QUESTIONS TO ASK. Under the last heading, mark each question with who should answer it: family, the bank or insurance company, the facility's billing office, a Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or not sure. Do not answer the Medicaid, legal, or tax questions, and do not suggest moving, spending, or retitling anything.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

One page you could hand to a professional and have them see where things stand.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the page. It's the start of the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've put what you know, and what you don't, on one page. The planning interview is the next step: answer its questions and it produces a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner.

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